

How to Build a Career in Open Source



If you are passionate about open source but don't know how to get started with a career in this domain, this article is for you.

Did you know that 80 per cent of maintainers find it a challenge to recruit new contributors and 92 per cent employers find it difficult to hire open source talent? On the flip side, 52 per cent of developers want to contribute to open source, 33 per cent do not know where to start and 31 per cent think they aren't skilled enough. As per data in the public domain, there is a lot of demand for people with open source skills. So let's see how you can build a career in open source to fill this gap between supply and demand.

Building a skill

The start of this journey begins simply by building on a skill that you are good at. Many developers work with

open source in their free time, building on unskilled areas and channelising these to tech fields. Skills like machine learning (ML), cloud native and Big Data analysis are in demand since many projects revolve around them.

Developers must try a lot of things, until they find what interests them. For example, I worked on mobile user interface (UI) and Web development (including front- and back-end), when I started working in the open source field. It did take a lot of time for me to figure out what I wanted to work on. So it's important to follow what interests you, and explore different areas by learning and building projects. A theoretical tutorial may not be as helpful as building practical projects. The only

way to skill up is to apply what is being learnt into a live project.

Once you have worked on a particular technology and project for a long time, it is the perfect time for analysis. If a project is uninteresting, it may be better to quit. However, this can be a double-edged sword. There are chances you may find something of interest that will lead to a trade-off later. Once a proper analysis is done and a skillset has been shaped, the next step is to build your own projects.

Building projects

Building a live project, irrespective of the content, has a lot of value. But remember, once it is open sourced, the public response should not be a factor that decides your next step. And whether you build a UI for an application or just document a list of proper notes, resources and URLs, your work can be of great help to open source users.

Learning about different tools helps build open source projects to a great extent. Hence, it is important to learn everything about version control systems, Git, GitHub and GitLab (where most of the projects reside). With sufficient tutorials available on the Internet, I have collected a few that can be found at navendu.me/osidays. One needs to 'learn in public' by documenting and making your findings public.

Building a career

You can build a career in open source in broadly three ways.

Build, scale and monetise your own open source project: Identifying